

Emerging Respiratory Virus SPOK-24 – Australia & International Spread

Situation Report – 3, published 04 November 2024 (Week 44)

Highlights

- Total of 192 confirmed hospitalizations across multiple Australian cities for severe respiratory infections negative for common respiratory viruses.
- Seventeen confirmed deaths, including pediatric fatalities, all testing positive for Virus SPOK-24.
- First confirmed international cases: SPOK-24 imported into Tokyo (Japan), Auckland & Christchurch (New Zealand), Port Moresby (Papua New Guinea), Hong Kong (China), Bangkok (Thailand), and New York (USA).
- The hospitalization curve for respiratory diseases has inverted its trend, despite declining cases of influenza, COVID-19, and RSV.
- Severe strain on testing capacity has led to delays and underreporting of SPOK-24 cases.
- A household transmission study involving 50 households with confirmed infections has started in Brisbane.
- WHO is convening an Emergency Committee meeting to assess whether SPOK-24 constitutes a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC).
- The CDC (United States) and several countries have issued Level 2 Travel Advisories, recommending testing for travelers from Australia.

CURRENT EPIDEMIOLOGICAL SITUATION			
1. Total Confirmed Hospitalizations (Negative for Common Respiratory Panels, Under Investigation for SPOK-24)			
Location	Total Hospitalizations (Cumulative)	New (Week 44)	Atypical Pneumonia (%)
Brisbane Metro, QLD	155	+40	
Townsville, QLD	9	+1	
Cairns, QLD	2	+1	
Rockhampton, QLD	5	+4	
Sydney, NSW	19	+4	
Melbourne, VIC	5	+4	
Hobart, TAS	1	+1	
TOTAL	192	+55	~22%

2. Confirmed Deaths (All SPOK-24 Positive)		
Location	Total Deaths (Cumulative)	New Deaths (Week 44)
Brisbane Metro, QLD	12	+3
Townsville, QLD	2	+0
Cairns, QLD	1	+1
Sunshine Coast, QLD	2	+1
TOTAL	17	+5
3. International Cases of Virus X imported from Australia		
- Tokyo, Japan – 1 case, mild symptoms, travel history from Brisbane (October 26). - Auckland & Christchurch, New Zealand – 3 cases, including a flight attendant (October 27) - Port Moresby, Papua New Guinea – 2 family members, symptomatic, traveled from Brisbane on October 28. - New York, USA – 1 severe case in isolation (NewYork-Presbyterian Hospital), confirmed positive on October 28. - Hong Kong, China – 1 case, travel history from Brisbane (October 30). - Bangkok, Thailand – 1 case, travel history from Brisbane (October 27).		
4. Transmission Patterns		
- Evidence of sustained human-to-human transmission, with increasing national and international spread. - Contact tracing efforts are overwhelmed in Brisbane due to the rapid increase in hospitalizations. - First confirmed household transmission study initiated in Brisbane with 50 households under investigation. - Nosocomial (hospital-acquired) transmission confirmed in multiple Brisbane hospitals and Townsville.		

Risk Assessment

- Current Global Public Health Risk: HIGH (Rapid international spread, rising hospitalizations).
- Likelihood of Global Spread: HIGH (Confirmed travel-related importations).
- Risk of Severe Disease: Elevated in young children and elderly populations.
- Testing Capacity Concern: Shortages in lab capacity are limiting case confirmations.

Next Steps & Global Response

- WHO Western Pacific Regional Office (WPRO) continues to collaborate closely with Australian health authorities.
- WHO is convening an Emergency Committee meeting to determine whether SPOK-24 constitutes a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC).

- Countries with recent travelers from Australia are advised to enhance screening for Virus SPOK-24.
- WHO will issue an updated Situation Report in 7 days or as more information becomes available.

For urgent inquiries and international reporting, contact the WHO IHR Emergency Team at [email contact].

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